The Politic

September 2019
Issue 1
The Yale Journal of Politics and Culture

Half the Sky

Surmounting #MeToo censorship in China

Inside: An Interview With Marianne Williamson

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First-generation, low-income students tackle Yale's invisible hurdles

December 14, 2017 was a big day for Logan Roberts. It was the day he came out, and the day he got into Yale University.

"I realized that [getting accepted into Yale] would dwarf the coming out," Roberts '22 said in an interview with *The Politic*. He could not recall anyone in his school's history having gone to a college like this one. "So I resolved to myself that if I got into Yale, I would also come out the same day."

An hour after receiving his acceptance letter, Roberts posted his coming out message on Instagram. Then, he went straight to performing "Paso Flamenco" in his high school band concert. Only after returning home did he tell his parents and two younger sisters about his college news.

"It was excitement for 30 seconds," Roberts recalled. "Then the next 30 seconds were, 'Don't get too excited. I'm not sure we can [afford to] send you here.'"

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"Before my junior year of high school, I had planned to go to the University of Illinois, just because if people from my high school went to college, that's where they went. And then my English teacher told me about QuestBridge." Paige Swanson '20 was raised in Rockford, IL, and she had only considered Yale to be a possibility after learning about the scholarship program.

Swanson, now a co-president of advocacy group First-Generation Low-Income at Yale (FLY), applied to QuestBridge's National College Match, a program that pairs students with colleges and a full four-year scholarship. While she ultimately did not gain admission to the College Match program, she received a "likely letter" from Yale a few months later.

"I remember my mom wasn't home from work yet and I was sitting at home for hours just like, 'I need to tell someone, I'm going to lose it.'"

The Directed Studies (DS) program at Yale has never been considered easy, but for Swanson, there was



an added layer of difficulty: "You get into class and there are kids who it seems like have read these texts in Latin since middle school. The experiences that you just haven't had can leave you feeling behind."

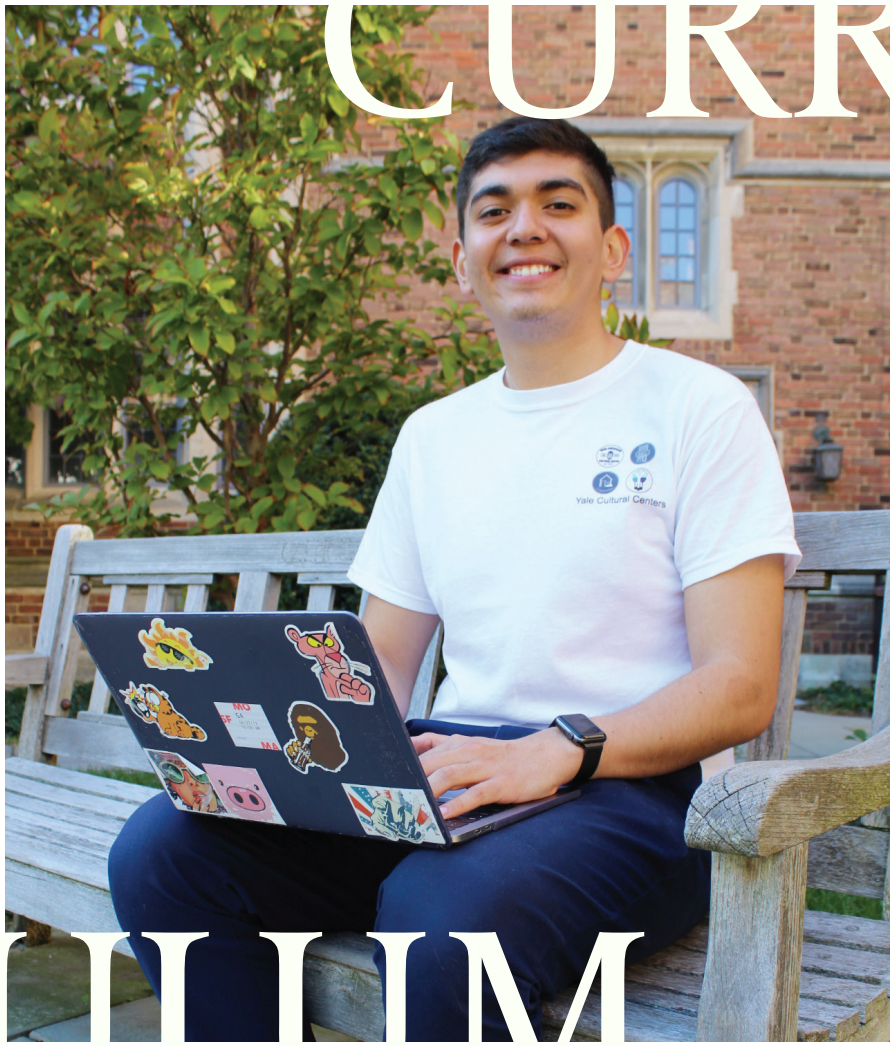
Yale is cognizant of this growing need. The Yale Class of 2023 has been touted as the most economically diverse class in the college's history. Over 20 percent of first-year students qualify for Pell Grants—a need-based federal subsidy for low-income students—for the second year in a row, and more than 17 percent of them are the first in their families to go to college. Linda Chin, an At-Large Delegate for the Association of Yale Alumni and an active member of the 1stGenYale alumni network, explained that the University is working to attract first-generation, low-income (FGLI) students. As a result, the school and student groups now offer a laundry list of support programs for FGLI students on campus, which provide services from pre-professional preparation to community activities.

But sometimes the need is not as easy to identify. "A lot of people in the first-gen, low-income community and scholars write about the 'hidden curriculum,' which is this whole other set of norms and practices that govern institutions of higher education like Yale." Knowing how to navigate office hours or how to write professional emails, for example, are skills that "are never taught but you're supposed to be able to figure out," said Swanson.

The hidden curriculum extends beyond these seemingly small hurdles; it is pervasive in a larger culture of academic alienation for FGLI students. Swanson explained, "Doing DS my first year made me confront a lot of these issues much quicker."

Jorge Anaya '18, a current Woodbridge Fellow with the Poorvu Center and the Coordinator of the Community Initiative, shared Swanson's feeling of alienation. "Academically, I felt like there was something that was always missing or something that other people were inherently better at than me,"

CURRICULUM



Jorge Anaya '18

he said to *The Politic*. "It was chipping away at my academic self confidence and I just didn't really feel like I belonged," he said.

Everyone at Yale enters the classroom with different academic experiences. Karin Gosselink, staff member at Poorvu and a co-supervisor of the Community Initiative, explained that "the baseline content knowledge some students were able to develop in high school can be uneven."

When Yale political science professor Andrea Aldrich, a former first-generation student herself, spoke to *The Politic,* she explained that she always tries to approach her classes with these diverse backgrounds in mind: "I was told to try to avoid the phrase 'So, we all know...' I had never thought about it before, but I realized that could make somebody uncomfortable because you could have a student sitting there thinking, 'Well I didn't know that. Does everybody else know that?'"

Not every professor approaches the classroom with the same mentality. Gosselink commented that "Because Yale College historically has been dominated by students from well-resourced private and public schools, faculty sometimes assume that students are all starting with similar levels of background knowledge in a given field."

Aldrich combats this phenomenon by emphasizing her personal experiences to make her students feel more comfortable. "I tell my classes right away a little bit about myself and put [my FGLI background] out there with the idea that maybe there is somebody in one of my classes that has a similar background and might see me as more approachable. I would have liked that [when I was] in college."

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In the spring of 2018, Roberts was invited to join First-Year Scholars at Yale (FSY), a five-week summer program designed to help first-generation, low-income students get acclimated to Yale. He was initially excited about FSY, but ultimately had to forfeit the experience and spend the summer working two jobs to afford everyday college expenses. While FSY recently expanded to 72 students, over 200 others who qualify for the program are unable to attend, either because it is financially infeasible or there is simply not enough space.

"I was jealous—I know that FSY would have been perfect for me; it's designed for people like me," Roberts recalled in an interview with *The Politic*, "but I just couldn't do it because I needed money in my pocket."

Karli Cecil '20, a former FSY student and later a counselor, explained that the program did more than just ease her transition to Yale during her first semester. Many of her closest friends today are people who also did FSY, even though they may not have been close during the summer program itself. On campus, Cecil explained, "those are the people I would migrate towards because they were familiar faces, but also I knew that they got me on a different level."

FGLI students at Yale often describe moments of "culture shock" when they feel as though they are out of place. "I had never heard of Vineyard Vines until I got here," said Anaya. "It's a small thing, but it's just uncomfortable knowing that there is stuff that is intuitive [to others], and for me I was just playing catch-up or pretending that I knew what I was talking about."

These culture shocks can manifest in larger ways, especially when it comes time for vacation. Many FGLI students cannot afford to leave campus every break, a luxury many of their peers enjoy.

"I remember I stayed here for my first October break and I was like 'Oh, everyone has left, this is sad,'" Swanson

recalled.

"I didn't feel intentionally excluded [at Yale]," Roberts said, but the quiet social alienation was certainly present. "Once your friends start going out to dinner or taking weekend trips to New York City, it's like a subliminal, inadvertent pushing to the side."

As a result, though many of his friends are not first-generation or low-income, Roberts said that "some of my best connections are with my FGLI friends because they're the people who can best empathize with where I'm coming from."

The Community Initiative has tried to build a broader FGLI community by sending out a weekly newsletter to FGLI students detailing upcoming community events and resources. A recent newsletter included details about an information session for FLY, as well as instructions on how to access the Career Closet, a new project spearheaded by the Community Initiative that allows students to check out articles of professional attire for periods of two weeks to wear to meetings, interviews, and other events that require formal dress.

First-generation alumni networks have also recently expanded. In 2016, Lise Chapman SOM '81 and Magda Vergara '82 launched 1stGenYale, a shared interest group designed to facilitate relationships with current and former first-generation students. 1stGenYale held its first conference in April 2018 to discuss the barriers first-generation students often face.

"The [Yale] Administration was very helpful in supporting the conference," said Linda Chin in an interview with The Politic. "The conference brought alumni together, and many of the alumni said that it was the first time they had been back on campus. And that says a lot. It says a lot about the feelings of belonging and alienation."

Swanson commented that, among other initiatives, FLY is working to get a dedicated physical space for a FGLI student home at Yale. According to Gosselink, "so many of these programs are relatively new," so it is still hard to measure their success.

It remains to be seen whether the efforts of FLY and the Community Initiative, along with older, more established campus resources can meet the needs of Yale's growing FGLI community. "Yale is trying," said Roberts, "but I think that more student input is needed, and more community cohesion is necessary. It's a work in progress."

"I thought that I was prepared, but you get into class and there are kids who it seems like have read these texts in Latin since middle school."



Logan Roberts '22

A deal for peace in Afghanistan and a fight by the forgotten

BY SHAYAAN SUBZWARI

RESISTANCE IN WHISPERS

In battle, there should be two brothers:
one to be martyred, one to wind the shroud of the other.

"Girls are dying from rape and stoning," Zarifa Adiba, 20, told me over the phone from her dorm room in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan. "They have been struggling and fighting to be known as human in this country for years after the Taliban['s] collapse." Adiba, now a student at the American University of Central Asia, grew up in the midst of the War in Afghanistan.

Throughout it all, Afghani women like Adiba have tried to find their own form of refuge from the war and violence. For some, like Rahila Moska, a 16-year-old from Helmand province, the landay—a cynical, two-lined Afghan poem—served as an escape: She would spend hours on the phone, writing and reciting love poems with a poetry group she attended remotely after her parents pulled her out of school.

For centuries, landays like Moska's have allowed the women of Afghanistan to play a secret game of telephone. In a whisper, they have passed the sardonic couplets from one to another as a means of anonymously expressing their suffering in a society where their voices are often restricted. As in any game of telephone, the whispers have evolved and changed over time as they travelled across society.

While the war in Afghanistan has raged on for the past 40 years, the landay has continued to carry out its duty, compressing the turmoil and terror of these decades into two terse lines. Compact with sarcasm and bitterness, the landay has come to represent the unquantifiable suffering of the Afghan people.

***

May God destroy the White House and
kill the man
who sent U.S. cruise missiles to burn my homeland.

Following the September 11th attacks, the United States invaded Afghanistan to dismantle the Taliban government, which provided refuge to al-Qaeda. After successfully removing the Taliban's Islamic Emirate, the United States has been battling Taliban insurgency forces, with massive casualties and little to no progress made on either side.

Given the thousands of American casualties, the lack of meaningful progress in the war, and the death of Osama bin Laden, many Americans find little reason for a continued presence in Afghanistan. In the September Democratic Party debate, mainstream candidates came out in support of troop withdrawal: Elizabeth Warren promised to disengage even without any peace deal, and other candidates, including Joe Biden and Pete Buttigieg, raised proposals to bring all the troops home by the end of their first term.

Although continued engagement does not seem to have much clear benefit, leaving poses its own risk. If the U.S. were to precipitously withdraw, Afghanistan could once again become a platform for large-scale international terrorist attacks as it was for 9/11. Leaving Afghanistan without ensuring that the Taliban doesn't continue sponsoring terrorism would allow al-Qaeda and similar groups to thrive, recreating the exact issue that the U.S. used to justify its initial intervention. With politicians across the spectrum calling for disengagement, the United States and the Taliban finally sat down for peace talks led by Special Envoy Zalmay Khalilzad this past year in Doha, Qatar.

However, with the possibility of a ceasefire just on the horizon, President Donald Trump unexpectedly canceled the peace talks on September 7th. Despite the past nine months of measured and cautious deliberations and a secret Camp David meeting with the Taliban scheduled later in the month, the peace process was brought to a

All landays included were taken from Eliza Griswold's book *I Am the Beggar of the World: Landays from Contemporary*

sudden and complete halt.

***

My Nabi was shot down by a drone.
May God destroy your sons, America, you murdered my own.

"In 2001, President Bush highlighted the objectives behind the invasion into Afghanistan. First was human rights, second was development, and third was dealing with terrorism," Intizar Khadim, a political analyst in Kabul said, in an interview with *The Politic*. "None of these objectives have been achieved by American forces."

Dr. Benjamin Hopkins, George Washington University specialist in Afghan history, had similar qualms. "What are the American war aims?" he charged. "I don't think America has defined those since 2001. It is really difficult to successfully conclude a war when you don't know what you're fighting for."

But then again, perhaps the American objectives in Afghanistan have changed in the past 18 years.

The United States initial involvement in Afghanistan was centered around developing Afghan society and dismantling the Taliban government. Today, the American government primarily supports the development of a democratic framework and works to deter the growth of the Taliban.

"I don't think the U.S. will pull out of Afghanistan, neither now nor in the foreseeable future. The baseline scenario I see is that the minimum the United States would have is a residual force of, say, 5,000 troops in order to ensure the viability of the Kabul government," Dr. Hopkins said. He echoes the feelings of those who believe America is too deeply involved in the conflict to realistically expect total disengagement in the near future.

Moreover, the effect of an American withdrawal from Afghanistan still demands consideration. In the 1980s, in a situation similar to the current U.S. involvement, the USSR fought insurgency militias in support of an unpopular Afghani government. In the aftermath of the 1989 Soviet withdrawal, Afghanistan immediately plunged into a turbulent civil war.

In the case of an American withdrawal, direct and unhinged warfare between the Taliban and the Afghan government could bring about a similar massacre of both sides, with the Afghan people placed directly in the crossfire.

***

O darling, you're American in my eyes.
You are guilty; I apologize.

During their failed talks, the Trump administration and Special Envoy Khalilzad attempted to mold a deal that would allow for a withdrawal while addressing the corresponding risks. However, even before the talks were canceled this September, they were plagued by criticism.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Barakatullah Rahmati of the Afghanistan Embassy said, "Any peace deal needs reliable implementing partners, and the people who are supposed to benefit should be part of the negotiations. In the discussion between the U.S. and the Taliban, these two elements were missing." Due to Taliban demands, neither the Afghan government—the implementing partner—nor the Afghan people had any say in the process.

In reference to this lack of representation, Adiba said, "Not only I but almost all Afghans have lost something in the war. If the Taliban want peace, they need to come and talk to all the citizens they have been killing."

Others have argued that setting aside American diplomats on the world stage has given the Taliban a sense of unprecedented legitimacy. With a Taliban spokesperson boasting that various foreign ministers are now vying to meet with the group, Rahmati believes that the Qatar peace talks have set a dangerous precedent for unwarranted recognition of the Taliban through direct and advertised dialogue.

With the contents of the deal kept largely under wraps, few had read the specific intricacies of the agreement prior to its cancellation. Of the few people who had seen the agreement, however, Secretary of State Mike Pompeo refused to sign the deal, citing it as too risky.

This could possibly be due to the Taliban had naming themselves as the "Islamic Emirate" on the final draft. A signature, therefore, could amount to recognizing the Taliban as the government of Afghanistan. Following a U.S. withdrawal, the Taliban may betray the agreement and continue fighting, leveraging the absence of U.S. troops. Any possible American withdrawal that doesn't ensure peace would effectively betray the Afghan people and America's alliance with the Afghan government.

***

May God destroy the Taliban and end their wars.
They've made Afghan women widows and whores.

When President Trump canceled the peace talks this September, he dashed months of negotiations and cautious hopes. The President's own reasoning was that the Taliban's recent attack, which resulted in the deaths of 11 civilians and an American soldier, demonstrates that they don't want to "negotiate a meaningful agreement anyway."

Adiba had her own take on Trump's reasoning. "It's very obvious that the [United States] will keep playing their dirty politics. Trump doesn't care who is dying and who is losing their loved ones," she said.

Many academics and politicians have speculated as to why the talks came to such an abrupt end. In an interview with *The Politic*, Dr. Shah Mahmoud Hanifi of James Madison University said, "I think Donald Trump kind of wants to meet with the Talibs himself. Maybe that is what this is all about."

Another possible explanation for the talks' failure could be Trump's negotiating methods. By pulling out of the talks, the President could be attempting to push the Taliban into a more desperate position, forcing them to give in to more demands before engaging in talks again.

Even if the peace deal had been successfully implemented, it remains only a single step toward solving the crisis in Afghanistan.

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I dream I am the president.
When I awake, I am the beggar of the world.

In the face of presidential elections this year, Afghanistan's fledgling democratic government prepares for one of the biggest tests in its 18-year history. Since the deposition of the Taliban's Islamic Emirate government in 2001, Afghanistan's government has been slowly working toward establishing a stable democracy. "Afghanistan is a democratic country. We are holding elections because we believe that the people have the right to select their leader," said Rahmati.

Khadim, however, as a non-governmental political analyst, doesn't entirely agree: "We don't hold elections for the sake of elections. We hold elections for strengthening the foundation of democracy, which is not happening. We want peace not elections for the time being, if peace is the problem right now."

The Taliban's desire to hold elections without peace would be "like asking a heart patient to run a marathon," former President Hamid Karzai said in an interview with the Associated Press. His lack of faith isn't entirely unwarranted: Looking at Afghanistan's previous elections, there has been a pattern of internal division and disagreement. The 2009 reelection of Hamid Karzai was characterized by low voter turnout and accusations of fraud. American pressure brought about an additional run-off vote which was eventually canceled due to an opposition boycott. More recently, in the 2014 election of Ashraf Ghani, disagreement and more accusations of fraud resulted in months of deadlock and eventually brought about the creation of the new Chief Executive position for

the losing candidate.

Concerning the upcoming election, Adiba offered the perspective of the Afghan people: "There is a lot of corruption, and all the candidates for presidency are against each other. Whoever is going to win, the others won't let them build the country."

If previous elections serve as any indication, the democratic foundation in Afghanistan is yet to be developed. The upcoming election looms with a forecast of increasing divisions and a risk to potential peace, not only with the Taliban but within the Afghan government as well.

***

Embrace me in a suicide vest
but don't say I won't give you a kiss.

As he talked on the phone, Intizar Khadim gave *The Politic* some insight into his take on Afghanistan's situation and future. "Afghanistan is a country where international forces cannot stay for long—they cannot stay with guns, but they can stay with pens. The future is that neither the Taliban nor America will defeat each other, and after five, ten, or fifty years, they will sit at a table. My hope is that the Taliban will integrate into Afghan society and that it happens sooner rather than later."

As Afghanistan stands at a moment where peace talks become a possibility again, the people still bear the brunt of each tilt and change. "We often think of politics as policies and structures and institutions, but it's really about the people," said Dr. Hanifi. "Whether it's how many dead or how many billions of dollars a day, the unquantifiable suffering of the Afghan people is where I want the numbers to start speaking to--and really, the voicelessness of the Afghan people."
For women, who are too often forced to be voiceless members of Afghan society, the prospect of the Taliban joining the Afghan government was yet another possible cause for suffering.

Adiba said: "As a woman, I was worried and afraid of thinking… [about] what [would happen] if the Taliban becomes part of the government, because during the peace talks we were getting these signals that that's what they want… The identity I have risked my life for and made for myself—I was afraid to lose it. My friends, too, were afraid of losing their identity."

To provide women with an outlet for their fears and experiences amidst their voicelessness, Sahira Sharif, an Afghan MP from Khost province, founded a social group in Kabul to share landays. This social group has expanded to include "cells" in eight provinces, although the women often must meet in secret.

"Most Pashtun women are not allowed to express their emotions in society, not even in poems. But the spirit to raise their voice is always alive in them," Sharif said.

As the peace talks have once again reached a standstill, the same Afghan people remain behind the frontlines, drone strikes, and bombed weddings. And as Khadim predicts, they will continue to remain there, vulnerable, oppressed, and silenced, until both sides are inevitably willing to compromise on a deal that brings lasting peace to Afghanistan.

My lover is fair as an American soldier can be.
To him I looked dark as a Talib, so he martyred me.

O darling, you're American in my eyes.
You are guilty; I apologize.

Jia Tolentino's "Feverish, Electric, Unlivable Hell"

The *New Yorker* writer's first book reckons with self-delusion and the internet

BY: T.C. MARTIN



In her new essay collection *Trick Mirror*, Jia Tolentino paints a bleak picture of our world of scams, mistruths, and self-delusions—all exacerbated by the internet.

Is there a way out?

On June 1, 2016, the internet lost its "I." That was the day *The New York Times*, following the lead of *The Associated Press*, began decapitalizing the word "Internet" when it appeared among its pages. Philip B. Corbett, the *Times*' associate managing editor for standards, urged everyone not to read too much into the style shift. In his article, he stressed three bulleted points. The change in capitalization did not "reflect a fundamental shift in society's view of technology," nor did it "signal some milestone in the history of online communication." Lastly, readers should not construe the new rule as evidence of "a 'legacy' news organization finally acknowledging the ubiquity of digital information." Basically, Corbett seemed to be saying, no tea leaves here.

As usual, the editor was right. The decapitalization of "Internet" in the *Times* could not be interpreted as a milestone of any sort—because the *Times* was late. The fundamental, historical shift Corbett alluded to had already occurred. Per Jia Tolentino's estimate in "The I in Internet" (the first of nine essays in her new collection *Trick Mirror: Reflections on Self-Delusion*), it happened in 2012, or thereabouts.

Born in 1988, the *New Yorker* writer (formerly of *Jezebel* and, before that, the now-defunct *Hairpin*) has witnessed and participated in nearly the full arc of the internet. It has saturated her childhood, her adolescence, and her writing career. And that saturation wasn't always bad. "In the beginning the internet seemed good," Tolentino opens her book biblically and fatally. Yet as she grew older, more complex, possibly more compromised, so too did the web. Recounting the story of her life and the story of the internet are eerily similar undertakings; the two are "inextricable." She writes:

> Did we truly want it to stop? It felt so good, then, and so different, to be watched.

"At ten, I was clicking around a web ring to check out other Angelfire sites full of animal GIFs and Smash Mouth trivia. At twelve, I was writing five hundred words a day on a public LiveJournal. At fifteen, I was uploading photos of myself in a miniskirt on Myspace. By twenty-five, my job was to write things that would attract, ideally, a hundred thousand strangers per post. Now I'm thirty, and most of my life is inextricable from the internet, and its mazes of incessant forced connection—this feverish, electric, unlivable hell."

The hyperconnection that the internet now demands of us, its exhausted and rightless citizens, as well as the monetization of that connection, have prodded us to cultivate perfect online selves. Tolentino differentiates the methods of that cultivation by platform—Instagram appeals to our vanity, Facebook to our pride, Twitter to our indignation—but the effective result is the same: a fractal performance of our ideal personas that saps us of money, data, attention, and time.

While the "I" in internet's spelling shrank with the web's ubiquity, the "I" we invested into it only swelled. The respite we usually obtained while performing identity in the real world (by switching, for example, from the role of employee to spouse, spouse to parent, parent to friend as we went about our days) became optional and increasingly rare on the internet. "Online," Tolentino writes, "your audience can hypothetically keep expanding forever, and the performance never has to end." We have deluded ourselves into believing our online identities are more real than our lived ones. In cyberspace, we are all seasoned method actors.

Tolentino's early life—like the lives of most writers, probably—hinted at a proclivity for self-delusion. The most obvious sign (and the one we encounter earliest in the book, on the first page of the first essay) is her prolific journaling. This habit takes many forms over the course of her collection. An Angelfire subpage was her chronicle of choice when she was ten. On it, she wrote about her germinal experience with the big-I Internet: browsing Beanie Baby websites on her family's home computer in the third grade. From then on, her digital world rapidly expanded to include dexterity with HTML and JavaScript, a personal Expage site whose storage space she quickly outgrew, and, eventually, her Angelfire page. It contained a journal section that she filled out dutifully for exactly one month in the fall of '99. "There was an FAQ page," her deadpan adult self interjects.

Tolentino periodically collides with her younger self through these and other early writings, in quite the same manner you might bump into your own reflection in a funhouse mirror maze. Each encounter seems to leave her a bit bewildered, sometimes embarrassed, but always boldly willing to stumble forward to the next *conk*. After all, the point of a journal, Joan Didion once wrote, is "to keep on nodding terms with the people we used to be whether we find them attractive company or not."

Tolentino's journals aren't her only point of

contact with her younger self. In her essay "Reality TV Me," she relates a more striking (and painful) reunion of past and present: watching a taped recording of a 2005 reality TV show on which she competed as a teenager. She submitted an audition tape for the show, *Girls v. Boys: Puerto Rico*, at a mall kiosk after her mother encouraged her to do so (and after her father bribed her with 20 bucks). By chance, the producers selected her, four boys, and three other girls to appear on the show. Throughout the season, the eight competitors raced, sparred, argued with, annoyed, and kissed each other, relishing being young and sunkissed and surveilled. And to think that they were brought together by some unlikely alignment of paternal bribery and a producer's whim.

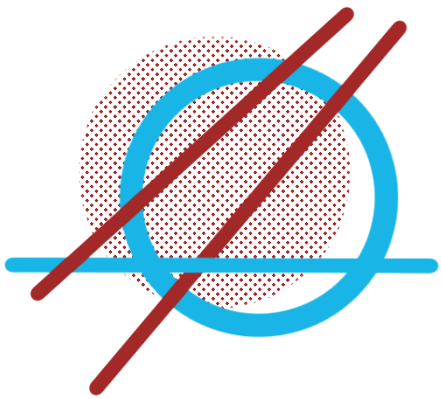
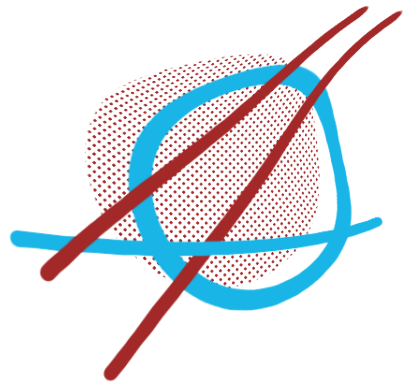
That's the story Tolentino admits she prefers: a story of pure serendipity and, on her part, apathy. Rewatching the show as an adult, she cringed not only at her teenage antics, but also at a pattern of delusion she could no longer ignore: "It seemed likely that I'd been making this error more generally. For most of my life I've believed, without really articulating it, that strange things just drop into my lap—that, especially because I can't really think unless I'm writing, I'm some sort of blank-brained innocent who has repeatedly stumbled into the absurd unknown." The truth, revealed to her by a journal entry in which her younger self displayed "excitement, but no surprise whatsoever," at being chosen for the show, was that Tolentino wanted to be cast. "It is now obvious to me... that a sixteen-year-old doesn't end up running around in a bikini and pigtails on television unless she also desperately wants to be seen."

Watching the taped recordings of the show evoked multiple such realizations from Tolentino. She noticed that an anecdote she often told about the show, one in which she is caught off-guard by a surprise eating challenge (her dish, when uncovered, revealed a plate of mayonnaise, a condiment she abhors), was actually false. The dish was never covered to begin with; she knew it was mayonnaise from the start, and she volunteered to eat it. She was always sincere in her telling of her story—it was simply untrue.

> Tolentino reserves her most acicular criticism for the scam of market-friendly feminism

Another delusion exposed: a fellow castmate of hers, a tender Southern boy named Cory, was caught up in a love plot with one of the girls on the opposing team. Now, years after the show first aired, he lives in Florida with his long-term boyfriend. In retrospect, Tolentino realizes, Cory, the "guy who loved Britney Spears and had never been kissed," didn't fit the stereotype of the heterosexual teenage boy. Multiple self-delusions were bound into one—Cory's, Tolentino's, and that of Cory's conservative father, who remains distant from his son to this day. All saw what was right in front of them, and all failed or refused to see that it was real.

Perhaps Tolentino's most unpleasant experience while watching the show was reliving the moments when she and six of the other competitors went after their castmate, Paris. They mocked her—Tolentino especially—by zeroing in on her need to feel pretty, admired, and attended to. Tolentino flogs herself for this in the essay, but in real life, she suffered no consequences for her brutal behavior. Granted, they were kids. Adolescence is barbarous by definition, and in her interviews with Tolentino, Paris seemed


to have let bygones be bygones. But more interestingly, there was no real mechanism for Tolentino's behavior to incur consequences in the first place. The program aired just before YouTube users began documenting every broadcast moment worth remembering (and many that weren't) for an anonymous immortal audience, a drama-hungry horde starving for both the calorific social carnage we associate with reality television today and the chance to litigate that carnage in the comments below.

Tolentino herself watched only the first episode of the series when it debuted and skipped the rest. In between the filming and air dates, she joined Facebook, the fatal bite that evicted humanity from our relatively edenic big-I Internet. "It was clear enough… where this was all going," she writes. "Reality TV conditions were bleeding into everything; everyone was documenting their lives to be viewed." *Girls v. Boys* was a unique opportunity for her to be watched without having to watch herself. "With this show, I could have done something that was intended for public consumption without actually consuming it. I could have created an image of myself that I would never have to see."

But by the time the show premiered, as Tolentino remarks, the self-documenting instinct was bleeding through. We seemed helpless to stop it, to imagine the bandage or tourniquet necessary to staunch our personal lives' seeping out into the digital universe. The helplessness, however, may have been a delusion in itself. Did we truly want it to stop? It felt so good, then, and so different, to be watched.

The internet's insidious influence can be found in many of the other essays in *Trick Mirror*, often in the background, accelerating things.

Though the internet did not invent the "ideal woman" figure described in "Always Be Optimizing" as constantly searching for and implementing new ways to self-improve, it has exacerbated her. Tolentino tracks the development of that figure, "an inorganic thing engineered to look natural," from the Victorian era to modern times. The major shift along that timeline is that, nowadays, the possibilities for optimization are seemingly endless and self-replicating.

For example: leggings. We can obtain what writer Moira Weigel calls a "frictionless" life by purchasing luxury athleisure clothing (which Tolentino calls "late-capitalist fetishwear"). The stretchy fabric from which leggings are made functions as a symbol for the outward comfort, flexibility, and seamlessness they command the modern ideal woman to embody. Of course, the comfort of leggings comes at a cost. Here again, Tolentino quotes Weigel: "Because these pants only 'work' on a certain kind of body, wearing them reminds you to go out and get that body." The frictionlessness of leggings produces a secondary friction—a desire to be slimmer and thicker in places that the leggings want us to be. We can solve that friction, we tell ourselves, with even more self-optimization (calorie-counting, weight-watching, Fitbit-fidgeting). It's Lululemons all the way down.

The internet figures even more prominently and perniciously in the generation-defining scams chronicled in the book's sixth essay. It's difficult to distinguish when the internet helped initiate these scams from when it allowed those who did not completely fall for them to laugh at those who did; in the end, the difference may not mean much. The already-classic example of April 2017's failed Fyre Festival demonstrates the ways in which the internet feeds into scams and thrives on their aftermath.

Organized—in the word's loosest sense—by well-known scammer Billy McFarland and rapper Ja Rule, Fyre Festival was marketed as a luxury music festival hosted on a private Caribbean island. It promised top-notch performances, gourmet food, and sumptuous lodging for party-weary influencers to rest within after a long day of spending money and being thin. McFarland purchased sponsored Instagram posts from Bella Hadid and Kendall Jenner to promote the event, which began disintegrating almost immediately after it was announced, since McFarland attempted to orchestrate it with just four months' notice.

The location was switched from a private island to a public one, namely Great Exuma, where a Sandals resort is located. (The festival was not hosted at the resort, but rather at a desolate lot nearby.) As Apryil neared, musical acts began to sense something suspicious going on with this new, untested Fyre Festival and started pulling out. When the weekend of the festival finally did arrive, hundreds of attendees became stranded on an island without the palatial accommodations they had been promised. They posted photos of what they received instead online, and the images became instantly indelible in the cultural consciousness. Those FEMA tents, those rain-soaked mattresses, those sad cheese sandwiches so similar to the ones public schools give to kids with overdue lunch debt: "the internet snorted each dispatch from Great Exuma like a line of medical-grade schadenfreude," Tolentino observes. We were hooked.

The other scams that framed Millennial viewpoints on culture, democracy, and success range from the 2008 economic crash to student loan debt, from social media and the "really obvious" cons (think raw water and Theranos) to Amazon's "octopus"-like economic reach and the 2016 election. But Tolentino reserves her most acicular criticism for the scam of market-friendly feminism, "the spurious, embarrassing, and limitlessly seductive sales pitch that feminism means, first and foremost, the public demonstration of getting yours." She discusses this in the context of "girlbosses," our society's capitalist figures that, at first glance, seem to represent feminist triumph over a corporate culture accustomed to shutting out women. The role of the girlboss can be traced through Nasty Gal founder Sophia Amoruso (grab your VIP ticket to her next "Girlboss Rally" for a mere $700!) to its technocratic mitochondrial Eve: Sheryl Sandberg of Facebook COO and *Lean In* fame. The doctrine such figures espouse is not entirely wrong, Tolentino says—but to accept without challenge the premise of that doctrine is to avoid reckoning with its myopic emphasis on personal advancement as feminism's ultimate goal.

That avoidance, she argues in another essay, is what often leads to progressive commentators defending (or even lauding) prominent conservatives like Kellyanne Conway and Sarah Huckabee Sanders, women with high rank in the Trump administration, as feminist icons. Tolentino is extremely aware that sexism does not discriminate based on party affiliation, and that Conway and Huckabee Sanders have undoubtedly encountered such prejudice in obtaining the positions they now hold. But those encounters do not anoint them as revolutionaries. "A woman doesn't have to be a feminist icon to resist [sexism]—she can just be self-interested, which is not always the same thing."

In the end, Tolentino is just trying to navigate the maze of connections and delusions like the rest of us. She acknowledges in her introduction that her position as a writer makes her a particularly unreliable narrator: "Writing is either a way to shed my self-delusions or a way to develop them. A well-practiced, conclusive narrative is usually a dubious one." She also implicates herself in her critique of the hellish internet, modern feminism, and the way the two feed on each other. (She partially credits that mutual consumption for her writing career.) It is easy to feel a kinship with her when she confesses: "I am complicit no matter what I do."

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Thankfully, *Trick Mirror* offers us anything but a tidy narrative. In her disorienting collisions with past selves and in her willingness to chase after and pin down the most circular questions surrounding identity, culture, and politics, Tolentino finds truth in the funhouse. Sometimes it is warped, reversed, and refracted in odd, unexpected ways. Its discovery requires her fearless pursuit of forward motion, even with the knowledge that she will crash into her own reflection time and time again. The revelations are worth the bruises. Let us all stumble after her, into the light.

HALF THE SKY

Surmounting #MeToo censorship in China

BY: KATHY MIN

"#MeToo has become a politically 'sensitive' issue in China now, so we cannot study it any more, even in academia. I hope you can also understand that we need to be anonymous in the #MeToo related issues."

For this reason, the professor The Politic spoke to requested to remain anonymous.

September 29, 2019

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On April 22, 2018, Peking University student and activist Yue Xin was shaken awake in the middle of the night—1 a.m., she recalled—by her school counselor and her mother. The counselor ordered her to delete all data on her phone and computer related to a records request she submitted 13 days earlier to Peking University. They insisted she give up the matter altogether.

Beneath the hallowed pillars, gates, and pagodas of Peking University, a sprawling campus located in the northwest corner of China's capital city and often dubbed "China's Harvard," lies the forgotten memory of a former student named Gao Yan. To the alarm of university officials and a mother fearful for her daughter's future, Yue Xin threatened to revive Gao Yan's memory from its 20-year-old shadows. "I love my mother," wrote Yue Xin in an open letter, published one day after the nighttime intrusion. "I'd deeply admired and respected her for 20 years. My

heart broke to see her wailing, slapping herself, kneeling and begging, and even threatening suicide."

In 1998, 21-year-old Gao Yan took her life. At one point ranked at the top of her class in Peking University's Chinese language and literature department, Gao Yan's intellectual prowess was at first a blessing but ultimately a curse.

Three years prior, she was one of 70 students hand-picked to study under Shen Yang, a then-renowned Chinese literature professor at Peking University. Only a year later, Gao was repeatedly groped and sexually assaulted by Shen, who was 20 years her senior. At the same time, false, malicious rumors that Gao had fallen in with Shen began to circulate.

"Gao Yan's smile would fade, her bright eyes flooding with tears. Even the occasional smiles would turn into tearful smiles," Gao's college roommate Li Youyou remembered in a letter published on April 5, 2018, that accused Shen of sexual assault.

After Gao committed suicide, Shen was absolved by the pursuing internal university investigation, which claimed that Shen was forced to be intimate with Gao due to her "mental issues." In the two ensuing decades, Shen remained professionally unscathed by Gao's suicide, later teaching at Nanjing University and Shanghai Normal University. (In April 2018, after Li published the open letter condemning Shen, Nanjing University suspended its contract with Shen, and Shanghai Normal University terminated its contract with him.)

On April 9, 2018, Yue filed her freedom of information request, demanding that the university fully disclose records of its investigation of Gao Yan's suicide. Four months later, on August 24, Yue and several other university workers and students, who were protesting workers' conditions in Shenzhen, were detained following an early morning police raid. Her current whereabouts are unknown.

Yue's experience is emblematic of the story of China's growing activist movement against gender violence—grim, yet also hopeful, with feminists resilient in the face of state repression.

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In the fall of 2017, the viral hashtag #MeToo took over the Western world, calling attention to the prevalence of sexual violence at all levels of society, from catcalling on daily commutes to the predatory behavior of movie executives and politicians.

In China, a country with 675 million women, "*Wo Ye Shi*" (the Chinese translation of "Me Too") caught fire among Chinese netizens in January 2018, when a woman named Luo Xixi accused her then-Beihang University professor of sexually assaulting her 12 years prior. Since then, Yue and many other university students have begun to call out sexual harassment on their campuses.

"There were thousands of people who signed petitions with their real names demanding that their universities implement some kind of mechanism to handle sexual assault cases," Leta Hong Fincher, author of *Betraying Big Brother: The Feminist Awakening in China*, said in an interview with *The Politic*.

After Yue filed her records request and published her letter in April 2018, there was an "incredible outpouring" of student support, according to Fincher. "Some classmates of hers at Bei Da [Peking University's Chinese nickname] actually wrote these big character posters, dazibao, in support of her and hung them up on campus," Fincher noted, invoking "very interesting historical parallels" to earlier student protests like the famous anti-imperialist May Fourth Movement in 1919.

According to Valerie Hansen, a professor of Chinese history at Yale University, student protests have historically had more legitimacy than other protests. "It goes back to the idea that students can say more than other people," Hansen said in an interview with *The Politic*. Alongside Chinese traditional culture that values scholarship, the Chinese government and society has viewed students protesters as a kind of protected group. "They have less to lose, right? They don't have families or property," said Hansen.

"Me Too has now spread far beyond university campuses," added Fincher. Within months of the first "*Wo Ye Shi*," sexual misconduct allegations were made against men ranging from the head of the Buddhist Association of China to the well-known television host Zhu Jun.

But as Xiaowen Liang, a Chinese feminist who now studies law in the United States at Fordham University, noted in an interview with *The Politic*, "*Wo Ye Shi*" only represents feminism's latest development in China. Liang first became involved with Chinese feminist movements in 2012, when she and other feminists launched a street campaign called "Occupy Men's Rooms," protesting the unequal wait times for men and women's public restrooms.

Throughout the years, Liang and other feminists have launched many other campaigns against sexual harassment and gender discrimination, partially as a response to what Hansen called a "huge erosion of women's rights," following China's economic modernization in the late twentieth century. With the entrance of women into the workforce, Hansen noted the emergence of pervasive glass ceilings. "People may say something that sounds pro-feminist, but in the actual reality of giving out jobs and hiring people, often men are given preference," Hansen said, noting pregnancy discrimination in employment practices.

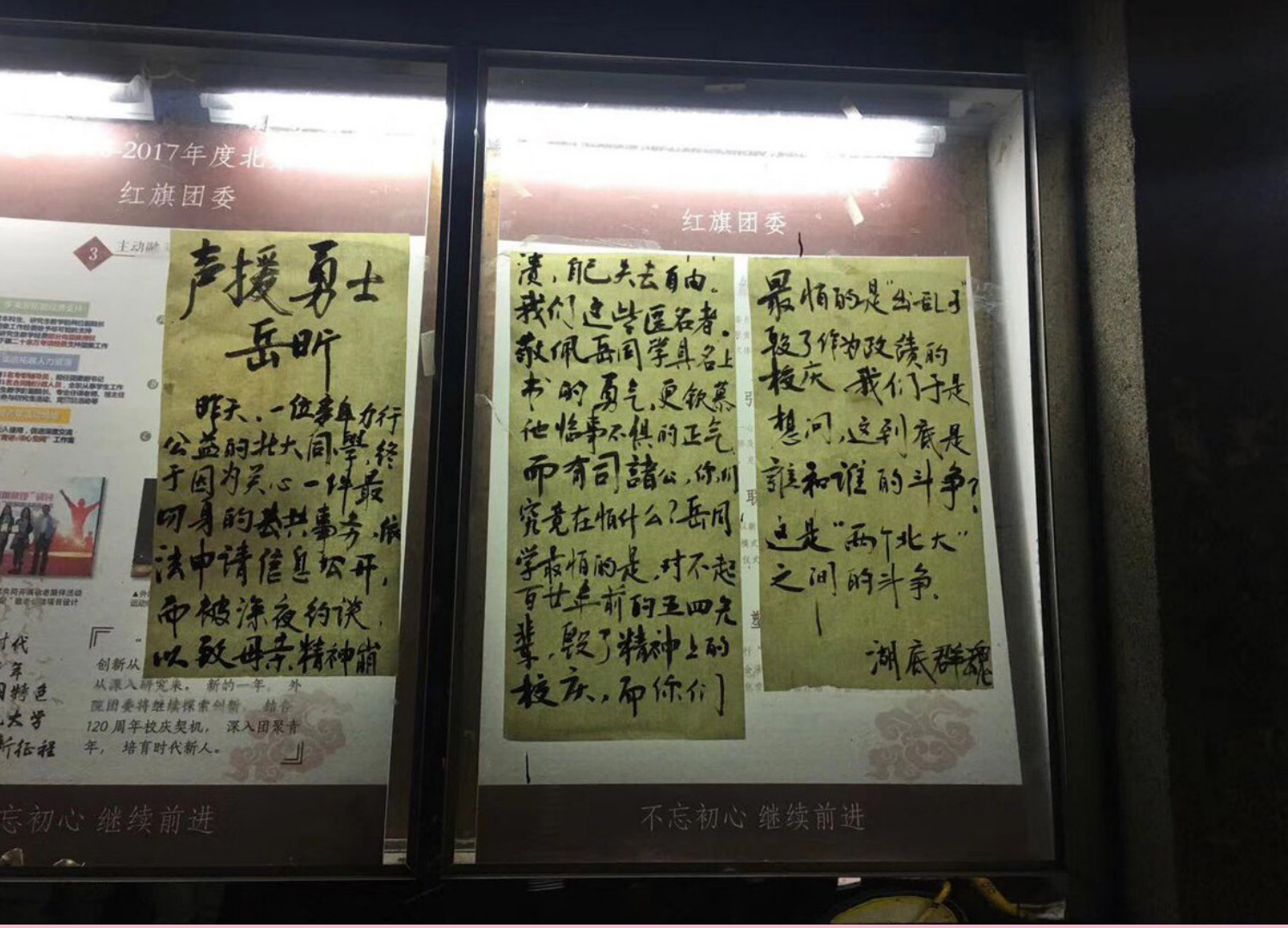
According to Liang, earlier campaigns helped lay the groundwork for #MeToo in China. She recalled the online criticism of a viral campaign in 2012 protesting sexual harassment on Shanghai's subway.

"Now when you read top comments this year about MeToo, you will see that it's a totally different scenario. People actually support victims. People actually know about anti-sexual harassment," Liang noted. "It's been six years… A lot has changed."

But Xu Yongqing, a student at the prestigious Jiaotong University in Shanghai, said that #MeToo has yet to take off outside of college circles, which "tend to be a little more open-minded."

In fact, "most people have not really embraced

"Now when you read top comments this year about Me Too, you will see that it's a totally different scenario. People actually support victims. People actually know about anti-sexual harassment," Liang noted. "It's been six years… A lot has changed."



this movement," Xu said in an interview with *The Politic*. Xu noted a general societal resistance towards feminism in China, which stems from both traditions and more recent controversies. "I think that some traditional ideas hinder feminism, such as the idea that a wife should obey her husband, as well as that women are objects and shouldn't have their own thoughts. In addition, there were some controversies a few years ago, where 'fake feminists' with 'boyfriend requirements' gave feminists a bad rap," said Xu.

Hansen agreed that traditional norms of *zhong nan qing nü*, which translates to "valuing men and minimizing women," would be hard to overcome. "I just think throughout Chinese history—or world history, really—almost all societies have valued men more than women," said Hansen, citing examples from Chinese traditional culture, like the preference for sons to carry on the family line, keep the family name, and worship the ancestral temples.

But the largest obstacle to #MeToo has come in the form of censorship by the Chinese government. According to Hansen, censorship has been deeply ingrained in Chinese policy throughout history, dating to the imperial era. "There's never been freedom of speech," she said, adding that the distinction between historical and modern censorship lies in scale. "I think the modern state can enforce it much more effectively," especially since President Xi Jinping's takeover in 2012.

In 2015, the Chinese government detained the "Feminist Five," a group of Chinese women who had planned to hand out anti-sexual harassment fliers on International Women's Day. "One of the big things Mao said was, 'Women hold up half the sky.' And that's quoted all the time," Hansen noted. Given that the Chinese Communist Party's official position has emphasized equal rights between men and women, Liang said: "No one could understand why the

government detained these people." But Fincher explained that the crackdown is due precisely to the movement's strength. The feminist movement is "perceived as a threat" not only because of its organization by "young," "prominent," and "quite fearless" feminist activists but also because of "the crossing over of women's rights issues—drawing attention to sexual violence—with labor rights activism, demanding better conditions for factory workers. It's that overlapping of class boundaries and also geographic boundaries that is seen as a threat to the Communist Party, because it shows the potential for mass mobilization."

In 2015, the government released the Feminist Five after a month, but Liang recalled continued government opposition towards other feminist activism. In fact, the government shut down Liang's feminist organization, which was "kind of underground," after the Feminist Five's release.

Liang noted how technological advances have made censorship even more widespread in recent years. Whereas ten years ago, "censorship was controlled and monitored by human beings," Liang emphasized that "it is now all machines controlling everything."

Hansen emphasized the importance of free speech to women's rights, contrasting the impact of the feminist movement in the United States to China's censored feminism.

"I think this is the big difference between America and China. In America, too, we have professors here who have been involved with things, and they're still teaching. But there's a free press, and we know about it," said Hansen. "But in China, I think the professors and the universities and the Communist Party have more power and that the protesting students have much less power.

"Yes, America is not an equal society, but I think for people who are on the bottom half of American society, there are certain kinds of things that they can protest. And they can protest without having repercussions," Hansen continued. "You wouldn't be jailed. You wouldn't really get into big trouble. Your life will continue, I think, in America. Whereas I think these student activists in China, I think their lives are going to change. I think the forces of power are entrenched in the West, but they're even more in China."

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In the face of such stacked odds, however, activists are resisting government suppression. To avoid censorship, activists have responded with increasing technological sophistication and creativity, from evading recognition software by distorting images to preventing the deletion of information via blockchain. Indeed, as the Chinese government clamped down on posts tagged "#MeToo" and "#WoYeShi," Chinese feminists began to change their vocabulary to dodge censors. "Me Too" became transliterated to "*Mi Tu*," which directly translates to "Rice Bunny." Circumventing text-based censors, activists incorporated the use of emojis to spread their message.

Activists continue to face obstacles in this technological tug-of-war, from the challenges of widespread public use to

"I think this is the big difference between America and China. In America, too, we have professors here who have been involved with things and they're still teaching. But there's a free press, and we know about it."



going up against the behemoth of the Chinese government's own technological capabilities. But activists like Liang see hope in their sustained resistance. In her view, #MeToo has enjoyed "decentralized" support from netizens across China. Liang said, "A lot of [articles on #MeToo] have been posted and posted, deleted and deleted, again and again." Despite the seemingly endless censorship, "people keep posting [deleted articles]," and "they do this all spontaneously."

Fincher agreed. "There have been some news reports that say Me Too has been slow to catch on in China, but I think that's the wrong take," Fincher said. "China is a police state. It's extremely difficult to organize any social movement, which is why all of the ones we've seen, they've all either fizzled out or been crushed… Me Too is still going."

In her letter, Yue was unafraid. "I am Yue Xin of 2014's matriculating class at the School of Foreign Languages... I'm battling exhaustion to write this down, but as a matter of principle," she continued, "I couldn't retreat."

when help might hurt:

how mass shootings have changed America's classrooms

BY ALICIA ALONSO

"Do you know what you just did? You just killed every single person in this classroom." As students tried their best to shrink into invisibility—crouching on walls, whispering under desks, and crawling under seats—the boy accused of murder laughed nervously. "Hey! Do you think it's funny that you just ended everyone's life?" As recalled by Julia Wu '23, the dean of Lake Highland Preparatory School in Orlando, Florida bellowed at a student, whose elbow was visible through the window of the classroom door. Three hours away from Parkland and amidst a nationwide epidemic of gun violence, an exposed elbow during an active-shooter drill alone was enough to warrant the dean's fierce reproach.

Following the announcement that the drill had ended, students emerged shaken but unsurprised. This was the new normal. In 2016, the Education Department's National Center for Education Statistics reported that 95 percent of American public schools now conduct lockdown drills. Most simulations involve sheltering in place, but others include more elaborate—and often more harrowing—experiences such as smoke bombs, a principal or police officer banging on doors, or audio recordings of gunshots.

And it is not only high school students who are subjected to such routines. According to *The Washington Post*, out of the more than 4.1 million students who experienced at least one lockdown or lockdown drill this past school year, approximately 220,000 of them were in kindergarten or preschool. Gun violence and fear have been co-opted into the school culture of our nation—and the measures intended to cultivate safety may be hurting the very kids they are designed to protect.

Experts question the appropriateness and effectiveness of active shooter drills. Only a small percentage of gun violence involving children occurs at schools, and the odds of a public school student being killed by a gun in school, on any given day since 1999, is 1 in 614,000,000, according to the same *Washington Post* editorial.

On April 20th, 2019, Ted Zocco-Hochhalter was on a business trip in Seattle when he received a call from Colorado. There had been a shooting at the school two of his children attended: Columbine High School. Immediately, he boarded the first plane back home. Upon his disembarkment, he was escorted to the hospital by four police officers and his brother-in-law. Nathan, Zocco-Hochhalter's 17-year-old son, had survived. Nathan's sister, 15-year old Anne Marie, had been critically injured; she was on life-support when Zocco-Hochhalter entered the hospital.

Zocco-Hochhalter, now a retired emergency management specialist, avoided public scrutiny for ten years, averse to retelling his story and reliving the tragedy. Nonetheless, in the past decade, he has become an advocate for school safety and gun violence prevention. In an interview with *The Politic*, Zocco-Hochhalter explained that "active-shooter-type massacres... are almost infinitesimally rare." He continued, "With my own family at Columbine, I could go off in the opposite direction and be very extreme in my approach to this, but the reality is active shooter incidents are still very, very rare."

The sudden increase of gun violence drills in schools is a symptom of media sensationalism but also of the well-founded terror that pervades our country. Gun violence is a very real and fatal public health crisis. Since the shooting at Sandy Hook Elementary School in Newton, Connecticut, there have been more than 2,000 mass shootings, as published by the Gun Violence Archive. Nonetheless, mass shootings constituted less than two percent of firearm deaths in the United States in 2018, according to the non-profit research organization Gun Violence Archive. As stated by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, about 100 Americans are killed by guns every day in non-mass-shooting environments.

Simply by the sheer frequency of sorrow, we as a population have become desensitized to gun violence. "There's shooting deaths almost every day in this district, every day in this country… I think that the normalization of mass shootings on some level may desensitize people. I heard a story where somebody was like, 'Did you hear about the mass shooting that happened last week?' and then this person asks, 'Which one?'" said Jeremy Stein, Executive Director of Connecticut Against Gun Violence. Yet, as a whole, shootings in schools tend to resonate more painfully and powerfully than in other settings and situations.

Maybe it is the tragedy inherent to ending a life so early, the dissonance between innocence and brutality, or the personal nature of such a calamity—pictures of young faces with books, playgrounds, and parks blurred in the background—that rouses rallying cries like "Hey, hey NRA, how many students did you kill today?" and signs that read, "I should be worrying about my biology test, not about dying."

Maybe it is the desire to do something, to pass some legislation, in the face of stasis and government inaction that has compelled almost every school in this country to implement active-shooter drills. "I don't know if these drills are data-based, if they're driven by fear, driven by some idea that [law enforcement agents] are trying to make themselves feel as though they have some control of a situation when they may not," Stein concluded.

Motivation aside, the effectiveness of these drills remains contentious. A number of child trauma experts are now saying that certain drills are far too intense and traumatizing for children, comparing the drills to those for police officers and people preparing for combat. The Department of Homeland Security developed a guide that describes what to do in the event of an active shooting; its first recommendation is to run and escape. Further, in 2012, the Education Department shifted its active-shooter response suggestions from sheltering in place to "options-based" approaches, like running, hiding, and fighting. Yet the majority of active-shooter drills take the "lockdown" approach instead, which is "not only counterintuitive but counterproductive," Zocco-Hochhalter asserted.

When asked whether active shooter drills are effective, Representative Sean Scanlon of Connecticut's 98th House District responded, "I do question whether or not doing these

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is effective… If you look at the situation in Parkland, the shooter had actually sat through one of these presentations [on how to respond to an active-shooter], and there is a question as to whether or not he gleaned information from that that he then used to harm more people. So I think we need to ask from a dual perspective."

Not only is there the possibility that active shooter drills feed into the culture of gun violence itself, but they may arm the shooters with the information necessary to perpetrate violent acts while harming the victims. While 96 percent of American public schools administer active-shooter drills—most required by state or local law—there is massive variation among the trainings and practices and of-

ten very little oversight. “There’s a lot of gray area with regard to active shooter drills… there are so many types of active shooter methodologies that people are putting forward… [active shooter drills today] are not being used in the right way. They’re being used to get a checkmark that we’ve complied… They don’t really put any thought or pre-planning into those,” explains Zocco-Hochhalter.

From these dramatic inconsistencies spring accounts of lockdowns with no warning. They precipitate tears and “good-bye” texts, the distribution of kitty litter during extended drills, and the drawing of bullet holes on students’ arms with felt pens to illustrate exactly how they would have fallen victim. “There is considerable variation in how drills are conducted across schools. At the extremes… some drills have led children to think they were experiencing an actual shooting. Yet these approaches increase the chances of terrifying children with no evidence to support taking such an approach,” adds Dylan G. Gee, Assistant Professor of Psychology at Yale University.

Back in that school in Orlando, Florida, no one had announced the dean’s intention to storm classrooms. The procedure of the active shooter drill itself had not changed—students were very familiar with the bell, the proceeding “code red” announcement, and all of the steps a lock-down drill compelled. However, the conduct of the administrators, the very same individuals conceivably responsible for remaining calm, was different. As the dean barged in through the fragile classroom door, the hearts of all 20 students jumped. In the few seconds between the emergence of noise and subconscious voice recognition, each student was silent and painfully still, paralyzed by fear and petrified by the unknown.

, Stein also compared
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"Oftentimes, schools may move forward with drills without giving careful review of how such drills may negatively impact students," said Christine Montgomery, Vice President of School and Community Based Services at Clifford Beers Clinic, a children's mental health clinic in New Haven, Connecticut. Montgomery proceeded, "If done correctly, safety drills are effective." However, far too many schools do not know what a "correct" active-shooter drill truly entails, which comes at the expense of long-lasting, chilling consequences.

As they are now—with inconsistencies permeating simulated life or death situations—active shooter drills are "not beneficial but traumatic," Zocco-Hochhalter comments. As Professor Gee analyzes, these drills "can be terrifying and have the potential to inflict psychological harm for some children, particularly those who may already be having difficulty with anxiety or who may have been exposed to trauma."

The overarching problem is largely the profound lack of research regarding the faults and merits of school safety drills. "We just don't know right now whether they are effective in terms of actually teaching the entire student body about them, and we also don't know whether they're doing more harm than good. And until we know the answer to those two questions, I think we need to look at the real problem, which is gun violence in this country and mental health in this country," maintains Representative Scanlon. Indeed, it is dangerous to have such high degrees of uncertainty in such a significant debate and formative setting.

It is possible that active-shooter drills may just be Band-Aids for bullet holes and a way to avoid addressing the true nationwide epidemic of gun violence. However, the key may not be utterly eradicating active-shooter drills but implementing comprehensive and informed exercises in their place.

"It is critical that drills be designed and conducted in ways that are developmentally sensitive, based on research on effectiveness, and in consultation with mental health professionals," elucidates Gee. Among the legislators, activists, and child psychologists interviewed, responses varied, but one idea emerged: there are preventative measures proven to be more effective and less traumatic that can be enacted expediently.

First, as Gee advises, "if a school is going to conduct active shooter drills, safety procedures should likely be focused on adults."

Montgomery adds, "If the adults are calm, the children will be calm. Scaring kids does not necessarily make them more prepared—it simply makes them more anxious."

Additionally, particular emphasis must be placed on the potential of students' prior trauma and the presence of existing conditions like anxiety. There are students and teachers who have not only survived a real-life active shooter

"If the adults are calm— the children will be calm. Scaring kids does not necessarily make them more prepared."

situation but may live in places in which they experience gun trauma on a daily basis, or have a friend or family member who has undergone a similarly agonizing situation. According to Stein, practicing active-shooter drills "re-traumatizes people as well. I know this from speaking to… a teacher that was at Sandy Hook when the shooting happened. We were talking about the first day of school last year. I said, 'How's school going?' and she said, 'Oh, you know, the first week of school, we had an active shooter drill'... and then it occurred to me: she's going through a drill that basically makes her relive the nightmare that she survived." There are several programs available that emphasize discussion-based exercises, such as seminars and workshops, in addition to operations-based drills that ensure that the community is alerted

prior to the event, and the primary objective is the furtherance of safety not the entrenchment of fear.

In an artful analogy, Stein also compared active-shooter drills to fire drills: "I don't think there's been many, or any, school fires where people have died. And the reason why that is isn't necessarily because of the fire drills; it's because of fire prevention." Along with standardization and well-roundedness, preventative methods are crucial to increasing the success of active-shooter drills. "It is very clear; we have answers… it would be one thing if we didn't know how to solve this problem, but we do; we do know how to solve it," asserted Stein.

The solution lies in further emphasizing "social and emotional learning," as Representative Scanlon proposes, as well as common-sense gun reform, both of which must work in tandem. Banning assault weapons, passing universal background checks and permit-to-purchase laws, and strengthening red flag laws is essential. The first step, as Representative Scanlon explains, is destigmatizing mental health counseling, "We have seen so much research over the years that shows that if people… are more in touch with their emotions and… that seeking out help is not a bad thing but actually a good thing, they're more likely to get treated and therefore potentially not do things like commit violent acts against their classmates or harm themselves." Then, through risk-protection clauses, we must ensure that appropriate authorities are aware of individuals who might pose a danger to others, so that they receive counseling, not access to firearms. And throughout, it is crucial that guns are only available to those with the capacity to wield such weapons safely.

Further, history has demonstrated that introducing more firearms to schools is not an antidote; in fact, there was an armed guard on campus when the Parkland shooter broke through the back door. "You can try to make your school like a fortress… make it as secure as a military armory, but it's not going to prevent the shootings as long as the real problem, which is the ease of access to guns, is allowed in this country," exclaimed Stein.

Representative Scanlon echoed such sentiments: "I do not want to be dismissive of school districts who are putting plans in place to deal with these shootings because that's absolutely what they should be doing. Administrators and teachers should be preparing for these things. However, he continues, "We need to look at the real problem, which is gun violence in this country and mental health in this country… We need to address each of them separately to try to combat these things together."

Scanlon, Zocco-Hochhalter, Montgomery, Stein, and Gee all illustrated a similar argument: The problem is not our students; it is not our teachers; it is not our schools. It is guns, the lack of effective mental health education, and the absence of truly effective preventative methods.

Thus, the remaining question may be whether these legislators, activists, psychologists, and educators can coordinate and collaborate to promote safety and avoid traumatizing our next generation before the next school shooting occurs.

An exposed elbow in a Florida prep school should not be cause for intervention, leaving students with lasting discomfort about their dean's profound overreaction. Students should not tremble with uneasy anticipation as the door of their classroom clamors open. Terror must be assuaged, not with anxiety-provoking, potentially ineffective drills but with educational and psychological support and legislative action.

As a country, we are becoming numb to the normalization of gun violence, as well as to the omnipresence of fear. "In the days after Parkland, I met with twenty or thirty Guilford High School students, and the first girl that spoke said that she was afraid to go to school because of what she was seeing on the news. People are already afraid," Representative Scanlon commented, but it does not have to be this way.

"What can we do to prevent these shootings? I believe the answer to that is by obviously passing tougher gun laws to make sure that's not even an option for somebody who wants to harm their classmates. And moreover, making sure that we have very strong social and emotional curriculums in place."



HOLDING THE FORT

PRISON GANG RULE IN PHILIPPINE JAILS

BY SAMMY WESTFALL



SQUATTING IN ORGANIZED LINES like a school group in an auditorium, hundreds of men in yellow stare straight ahead. They aren't watching anything in particular. The men nudge, scratch, and fan themselves with ice cream carton lids and torn cardboard box flaps while Philippine pop music blares overhead. They've all gotten used to the smell. The shadow of overhanging tarps draws a harsh line through the basketball court, separating sun and shade. Fighting for a slice of the cool, the men press together. They move like an interconnected machine along with the changing sky: when the clouds move to conceal the sun, then men diffuse. When the sun reveals itself, the men retreat into the congested comfort of the court's shaded corner. The men all wear yellow—a yellow replica Lakers jersey here, a yellow Spongebob t-shirt there, but mostly the official government-issued yellow t-shirt emblazoned with "*PDL Person Deprived of Liberty.*" In smaller letters lining the shirt's hem is the too-cheery motto, "Changing Lives, Building a Safer Nation." This is Quezon City Jail.

It's a 92-degree-Fahrenheit morning in Manila, and today is "Friendship Day." On typical jail visitation days, only immediate family is allowed. But today, friends and distant relatives have arrived from around the island nation. The visitors—mostly women—stand in a winding line enforced by steel barriers, waiting with Tupperware containers of home-cooked meals and biscuits. The guests wait to be patted down or strip-searched, or for the unlucky few—cavity-searched for hidden drugs. Guests are welcomed to Quezon City Jail (QCJ) with Filipino signs: "Prohibited are ADDICTS at QCJ: Abuse, Drug Addicts, Irresponsible, Corrupt and Complicit in Smuggling Drugs." Another Gatsby-esque sign features only two towering, knowing eyes: "*May Kontrabando Ka Ba?*"—"Do you have contraband?" Inside the jail, visitors weave through the basketball court's dense canary-colored sea. "Friendship Day" is also the reason so many men are sitting on the jail's outside court; making space for guests who meet inmates inside the cells, the court-bound men have no visitors.

Overlooking the central court from three floors above, three grey-uniformed Bureau of Jail Management and Penology (BJMP) officers sit in a watchtower. The jail's total area is 1,233 square meters—one-fourth the size of an American football field. In the watchtower hangs a mini-whiteboard with the jail's exact population: 5,117 inmates. UN standards dictate that a facility this size

should house 262 people. Space shortage means cells are left unlocked day and night; inmates are free to roam to find a place to lie down—for some, that means sleeping on the basketball court, on steel staircase steps, or in toilet stalls. Quezon City Jail houses many who wait for years before receiving a sentence—some lost completely in the justice system.

Over 80 percent of QCJ inmates are charged with drug-related cases—a number that has skyrocketed since President Duterte stepped into power. "You drug pushers, holdup men, and do-nothings, you better get out, because I'd kill you," Duterte proclaimed in the last speech of his successful 2016 campaign. "I'll dump all of you into Manila Bay and fatten all the fish there." In the bloody war on drugs that followed his inauguration, 5,000 were extrajudicially killed, according to Philippine Drug Enforcement Agency statistics. Human Rights Watch has the death toll at 12,000. Within four hours alone in May 2018, Quezon City saw seven drug suspects killed on the streets by vigilantes and national police on Duterte's indirect orders. Over 24 hours in February 2019, 1,406 people were arrested and 65 sachets of *shabu*—Philippine crystal meth—were confiscated by the police.

While uniformed BJMP officials in the watchtower loom over the thousands of inmates, a less formal, but more heeded, system keeps the prisoners in check: four prison gangs or "*pangkat*"—*Sputnik, Commando, Bahala Na Gang* and *Batang City Jail*—hold Quezon City Jail together. With a guard to inmate ratio at approximately 1:300—and an ideal ratio closer to 1:7—prison gangs and their internal leadership fill institutional gaps in the established jail management system. Inmates elect their own gang leaders and work collaboratively with official guards. Outside, in Metro Manila, chaos reigns. People do what they must—even if that means breaking laws—to survive. Here, in the prison, inmates follow their own rule of law to survive. In a facility riddled with institutional deficiencies within a country in political turmoil, it is prison gangs—composed of the Philippines' supposedly most unruly, most disobedient, most criminal—that maintain control, instill self-discipline, and create a culture of respect.

"IT'S SORT OF A FAMILY," said Ronel—whose name has been changed for privacy reasons —of his gang. Unlike most at Quezon City Jail, Ronel is already convicted but is waiting on a stubborn few documents before he can be transferred to the 26,000-inmate-strong national penitentiary, New Bilibid Prison, to carry out his six-year sentence. Ronel, a Philippine Drug Enforcement Agency officer for over a decade, was arrested in May 2018 on charges of "malversation of public property." In his words: he was caught "not returning government property" entrusted to him. His family does not know he is imprisoned. Ronel's LinkedIn profile—still online and untouched since 2018—lists him as an Intelligence Officer.

Ronel, now 45 years old, is a proud member of the *Commando* gang. Slipping in and out of English and Tagalog, Ronel whispers and folds and refolds his hands as he speaks.

"*Kasi first timer, diba*?"—"Because I'm a first timer, right?" Ronel said of his choice to affiliate with a gang. Working in the Philippine Drug Enforcement Agency, Ronel had heard of the prison gang system from ex-offenders he interviewed. Upon his own arrest and facing the notoriously forbidding Philippine jail system, Ronel craved a sense of security. Soon-to-be prisoners usually choose their gang affiliation before even stepping foot in the jail during lock-up in police station holding cells, where other detainees actively recruit members for the four different gangs.

Three years before his arrest, Ronel got a full-shoulder tattoo of a Viking riding a tiger—coincidentally, each a symbol of two different gangs, *Commando* and *Bahala Na Gang*, respectively. With two options, Ronel chose the former. "After I chose *Commando* I had to get a symbol—three balls," Ronel said, holding up his right hand emblazoned with a triangle of small dots, marked by another *Commando* member, in the area his thumb meets his index finger. Other gangs require tattoos of either one, five, or four dots. When Ronel first entered Quezon City Jail, the officers checked for this insignia, wrote his official gang affiliation on the prison record, and then, as is policy, separated him into a gang-assigned cell. *Pangkat* have become institutionalized.



RAYMUND NARAG IS AN ACADEMIC armed with a Fulbright, three book publications, and a PhD—and the title of former QCJ *Mayor de Mayores* of *Querna*. Following a fraternity brawl at the University of the Philippines Diliman that left one dead days before his college graduation, Narag was wrongfully charged with murder—two counts of frustrated murder and three counts of attempted murder. Narag was an inmate at Quezon City Jail for "six years, nine months, and four days, to be exact," he said. After his acquittal in 2002, Narag researches criminal victimization and correctional administration while working as an assistant professor in Criminology and Criminal Justice at Southern Illinois University. Narag sees the pangkat gang system as a structural response to the jail's root problems: overcrowding, slow judicial work, inadequacies in facilities and personnel.

"In one way or another we have to accept that the gang has helped us maintain peace and order," said Lucila "Luz" Abarca, a QCJ officer. She calls the relationship between gangs and officials "shared governance"—both cooperate to hold down the jail. Violence sometimes erupts, though. When there is tension among gangs, it is clear. The basketball court falls silent—"as if everyone is watching each other, on the watch for any attack," Luz said. When any trouble arises, officials conduct investigations into who started the trouble. But unless the transgression is particularly offensive, the gangs can control the punishment. "It's between them," Luz said.

Jayrex Bustinero, a BJMP officer for the past 11 years, said that working together with the *pangkat* is a "natural coping mechanism" for under-resourced guards. Five times a day, starting at 5:30 a.m., BJMP officials conduct a prison-wide head count. To compensate for understaffing, gang leaders organize their own members in time for the count. Each gang, too, has their own Magna Carta posted in their cell, mandating self-discipline, good behavior, and protection and love for visitors and fellow inmates. Jayrex said that the rules are in line with BJMP policies, adding that the first rule for every gang is "*Respeto al Empleado*"—"Respect the Employees."

Scotch-taped onto the wall of every gang's main cell is a *pangkat* "gallery" of the gang's leadership. For the *Querna*,



their smiling headshots overlaid on a red and blue gradient background are posted up in a pyramid foundation under a bubble-lettered title.

At the top of the Philippine jail gang hierarchy sits the *Mayor de Mayores*, who sets rules and attends weekly meetings with other gangs' *Mayores* and the BJMP jail warden. There are two assistant leaders called *Mayors*. The *Kulturero*, or gang secretary, writes letters of concern to the QCJ warden to request, for example, an additional electric fan or light bulb replacement. He also can access the jail records to provide case file assistance to fellow gang members who cannot read or write. The *Treasurer* takes care of the gang's funds—to purchase cleaning materials and medicine—in an empty five-gallon water bottle full of the gang's *peso* bills hanging from the cell's ceiling. The *Jury* is a group of more than five—who served time in the national penitentiary—that oversee discipline. While punishments are not always violent, the *Jury* can choose to inflict paddle blows as punishment—an underground practice discouraged by BJMP officials. The *Bastonero* is the individual, armed with a *baston* or cane, who carries out the paddling.

All Quezon City Jail gang leaders are elected democratically and confined by term limits. Jail officials supervise the elections, which happen often because of the high *Mayores* turnover rate due to convictions, releases, and cross-facility transfers. BJMP officials screen potential gang leader candidates for their reputation and any jail violations. On election day, officials place a ballot box in each cell, and democracy commences for the *Persons Deprived of Liberty*.

Former QCJ officer Jayrex Bustinero remembers one election during his 2014-2017 QCJ guard term. Once the prison-wide voting process ended, officials set up an elevated stage at the right side of the jail's basketball court. QCJ then-warden Ermilito Moral, clad in a white embroidered *Barong Tagalog*—traditional Filipino formal attire—facilitated the oath-taking of new gang leaders. Moral spoke into the microphone while the newly-elected gang leaders lined the stage with their right hands raised. Sitting in plastic chairs on the court and peering down from the jail's second floor, the inmates watched as the gang *Mayores* swore to perform their jobs, to follow the regulations set forth by management, and to protect the welfare of the inmates.

To celebrate the election, jail officials set up a *boodle fight*, a Filipino tradition of communal feasting derived from Philippine military meals. On the court, officials cover long rows of plastic tables in deep-green long banana leaves with a trail of white rice running down the middle. Scattered on the leaves were tiny mounds of *pancit* noodles, *adobo* chicken, and *ulam*, which the group ate together—keeping with local tradition, by hand. Hundreds of inmates joined the warden and officers for the feast in what Jayrex described as a "symbol of unity" that reflects the Philippines' collectivist culture. Jayrex described the untranslatable concept of "*pakikipagkapwa*" as a harmonious relationship. "If you have good *pakikipagkapwa* with someone, they will return good *pakikipagkapwa* to you," Jayrex said. "You can see that in all the Philippine jails." Moments like the shared, hands-only food fiesta are a rejection of guard-gang-prisoner animosity and are uniquely Filipino. "I don't know, it's normal," Jayrex said. "It's normal here."



MARCO, A 32-YEAR-OLD *Bahala Na Gang* member whose name has been changed is one of at least 4,300 QCJ inmates charged with violating Republic Act No. 9165: possessing and selling, or delivering drugs. Marco claims that he was set up by *Barangay* captains—village watchmen—who snuck *shabu* onto him during his 2005 arrest. "If you don't belong to a [*pangkat*], you can be bullied," Marco said, his voice muffled underneath a disposable earloop face-mask. But still, if he could go back and choose again, he would stay gangless. He doesn't think the *pangkat* life worth it, with the daily restrictions and the potential for violent punishment. In the Philippine jail system, unaffiliated inmates automatically become a part of *Querna*, its own cohesive unit mirroring the *pangkat*, with *Mayores* and a miniature bureaucracy. At Quezon City Jail, at least 800 inmates are *Querna* and live separate from the gangs.

"[The *Querna*] don't have rules," Marco said. But then he backtracked—"They have rules, but not like us." He said that *Bahala Na* inmates can be hit or made to do "community service," like cleaning, for small infractions. The *Querna*, on the other hand, get "padlocked" in a private cell temporarily for transgressions. Raymond Narag affiliated with *Querna* because it sees less intra- and inter-gang violence. Unlike the gangs, though, *Querna* are not obligated to each other in the same way. When a *Sputnik* member is ill, for example, others get him water, clean up his sick, and pay for medicine with the water bottle-held funds. *Sputnik* sees strength in numbers, and members back each other up when they feel threatened. Narag chose to forgo these benefits to preserve his individuality and freedom of action.

MORE THAN JUST A STRUCTURAL and organizational benefit to the jail, gangs grant inmates an essential sense of importance. "If you are a member of *Batang City Jail*, then *Batang City Jail* will always tell you 'You're number one. You're good. You're family to us.' And if you talk to *Sputnik*, they will also say 'We are number one. We are the best here,'"

said Narag. This belonging is a source of recognition and pride for inmates who, outside Quezon City Jail, are stripped of their good names. Inside, they are part of a family. With the *Mayores* as the father, the inmate's role is the "dutiful brother." They begin their jail term as the *bunso*—the youngest in the family—and grow to become the *kuya*—the eldest. Ray, the gang's *Mayores*, is in his late 30s. Like all gang members, 45-year old Ronel calls Ray "*Tatay*" or Father.

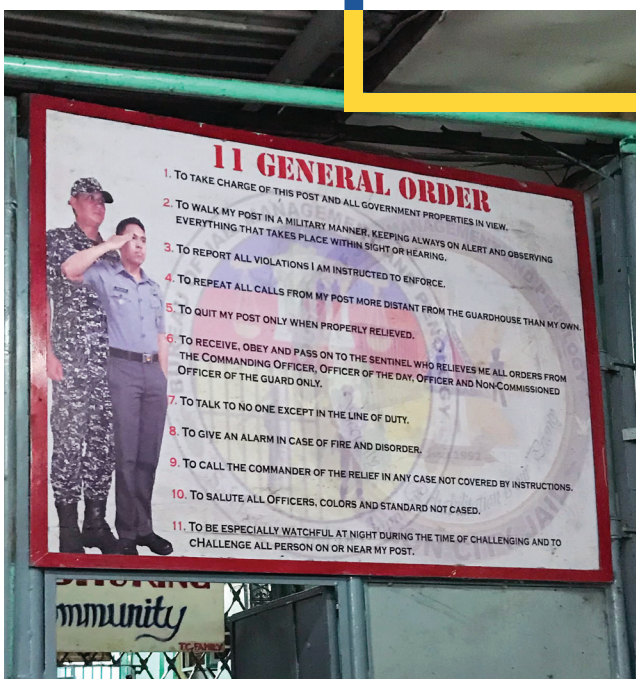
Ronel is considered "*walang dalaw*," a label for the class of people with no outside family or friends to visit them. Instead, on days like today when his fellow *Commando* members have visitors, they allow Ronel to tag along and eat lunch with the group.

"*Parang na sa bahay lang*"—"It's just like being at home"—Ronel said of life in the gang. Each of the 16 cells has its own television set—but every cell has 130 to 1,220 people. The gang takes a majority vote to choose which channel to watch. Usually, it's an action movie. Ronel had just watched 2007 Crime Drama *Hitman* with the other *Commando* members. "*Ganda rin*," Ronel said. He enjoyed the film.

In 2016, the Philippine government proposed separating inmates by risk—splitting violent offenders from those with drug-related cases—rather than by gang. But Quezon City Jail lacked both the resources and physical space to do that. Maybe it was for the better.

At the end of the 92 degree morning, a group of inmates take part in a rehabilitative seminar: balloon sculpture making. At least 30 men representing different gangs sit in green plastic chairs at a long row of collapsible tables, closely following a woman demonstrating. The yellow of their shirts peeks through a mass of pink and white balloons, which hover inches over the table like a giant cloud. With their differently-dotted hands, the men use delicate fingers to help each other tie balloons together. The men shout in collective fear when one balloon pops.

Without gangs, Jayrex said, "I think the system will collapse."



Marianne Williamson

2020 Democratic Presidential Candidate

The 2020 presidential candidate talks love and apathy

By Andrew Bellah

HOW'S THE CAMPAIGN PROGRESSING? WHAT ARE YOU CURRENTLY WORKING ON AS THE CAMPAIGN MOVES FORWARD? ANY LESSONS?

WILLIAMSON: The campaign is progressing fabulously, thank you for asking. I've seen consistently deeper understanding of a conversation that I think so many of us are yearning to have.

I don't wake up in the morning and worry about what I should be saying to a particular group; I wake up in the morning and think about what I think needs to be said. And I think subconsciously, we all have a kind of collective yearning for a new conversation and a new path forward.

I think we do have meaningful conversations in the private sphere. But in the public sphere, especially politically, we talk so superficially. Out of that superficiality grows some very dysfunctional political realities– —and those political realities will not be transformed until we have deeper conversations with ourselves.

IN *HEALING THE SOUL OF AMERICA*, YOU WRITE A LOT ABOUT HOW WE NEED TO USE LOVE AND UNDERSTANDING TO OVERCOME A POLITICAL REALM CONFOUNDED BY HATE. DO YOU THINK THAT'S THE BASIS FOR THIS CONVERSATION THAT PEOPLE WANT TO HAVE?

Absolutely, because the only thing that overrides and disperses hate is love. Whenever something hateful and awful happens, everybody finds a quote online, tweets it out, and makes it their screensaver. We need to go beyond that. We have to make real what we already know to be true.

The idea that love is to fear is what light is to darkness is a metaphysical concept that people intuitively understand. You can't just hit darkness with a baseball bat– you have to turn on the light. The only way we will overcome collectivized hatred is through collectivized love. This is not a new concept. This is a new iteration of what is not only a well-established political philosophy but the driving force behind two of the most successful and radical political movements of the twentieth century– the Indian Independence Movement and the American Civil Rights Movement.

"The idea that love is to fear is what light is to darkness is a metaphysical concept that people intuitively understand. You can't just hit darkness with a baseball bat– you have to turn on the light. The only way we will overcome collectivized hatred is through collectivized love. This is not a new concept."

So yes, it's the larger context. I read an interview with Jared Kushner a few years before the 2016 election, where he said to his father-in-law that there's a lot of angry people out there, and that we can harness all that anger for him to become president.

And when I read that, I thought to myself that there are so many good, loving, decent and respectable people out there, and that we could harness all of that for the betterment of the country. And that's what we're talking about here– we're talking about how we can translate love into a political force. I don't think anything less than that will be able to transform this country, and I don't think anything less than that will defeat this president.

YOU TALK ABOUT HOW PEOPLE SOMEWHAT PERFORMATIVELY TWEET THINGS OUT, OR SAY THINGS, BUT HOW DOES SYMBOLIC LOVE CREATE REAL CHANGE?

It creates real change because it makes you incapable of keeping your mouth shut, sitting and conspiring in silence when injustice and evil are having their way. As they say, "The only thing necessary for the triumph of evil is that good men do nothing."

A generation cannot live righteously if we are only living for ourselves. And as a woman who considers herself a feminist, sisterhood is absolutely everything. This can't just be sisterhood with women in American either, it has to be sisterhood with women internationally too.

When I saw a Washington Post article about my stance on the Afghani women, I realized that speaking up, without knowing if anyone is going to hear you or care, can really land with people sometimes. It may be a tweet, an Instagram or Facebook post, an article that you share, write, or even comment about! Each of those is a way of speaking up, derived from an inability to keep silent any longer about things that you believe matter.

Just don't shut up! We have been so mentally trained to just chatter endlessly about things that ultimately don't matter, and it's killing us.

DO YOU THINK THIS MEANINGLESS TALK IS A PARTICULAR PROBLEM? WHAT ABOUT WITH YOUNGER VOTERS WHO FEEL DISENGAGED FROM OR APATHETIC TOWARDS THE POLITICAL SYSTEM?

The general trend is that young people are always the voice of audacity that does not shut up. But also, political audacity comes when you pass a certain age. When I turned 50, someone told me, "50 is the age where you no longer care what people say." And then when I turned 60, I realized that it was the age where you no longer care what other people say, but you cannot not say what you want to say.

It's those years in between where people are being sucked into the capitalist illusions, making the world as the world defines it, and getting waylaid by some of those forces.

"It's ***those years*** in between where people are being sucked into the capitalist illusions, making the world *as the world defines it*, and getting waylaid by some of those forces."

Now when you say it is "apathy," I don't think apathy quite names the concern. Beneath the surface of most apathetic people is someone who is paralyzed by fear or resignation. But human beings aren't apathetic – we're hard-wired to care. And when we've been apathetic for so long, it's almost like a muscle spasm, like we've suppressed an innate urge by blocking it.

ABSOLUTELY. IS THERE ANYTHING ELSE THAT YOU WOULD LIKE TO ADD OR LEAVE WITH?

I'd like to point out how fortunate we are to have this conversation. As a woman, I'm particularly aware that there are places in the world where I would be jailed, tortured, or even worse for saying even a fraction of what I say every day. Whenever we're talking about the "underbelly" of things, we should also hold in mind that we've done a lot right, that so much more remains, and that we're trying so hard to change American because of how much we love our country.

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